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RECORD-JOURNAL

Connecticut school districts involved in PowerSchool data breach, officials say

By **Crystal Elescano**, Staff writer

Updated Jan 8, 2025 5:35 p.m.



Highland Elementary School in Wallingford, Conn., Thursday, August 29, 2024.
Dave Zajac/Hearst Connecticut Media



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Connecticut school districts involved in PowerSchool data breach, officials say

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School districts across [Connecticut](#) are notifying parents about a cybersecurity data breach involving PowerSchool, the company that provides their student information system.

Milford, Wallingford, Danbury, Region 16 and East Hartford were among those affected, according to the districts.

On Tuesday, PowerSchool released a statement to administrators about the cybersecurity incident that took place on Dec. 28.

“Over the succeeding days, our investigation determined that an unauthorized party gained access to certain PowerSchool Student Information System customer data using a compromised credential, and we regret to inform you that your data was accessed,” the statement said.

As soon as the company learned of the incident, they immediately engaged with their cybersecurity response protocols and mobilized a cross-functional response team, including senior leadership and third-party cybersecurity experts, according to a PowerSchool spokesperson.

To contain the data breach, PowerSchool has deactivated the compromised credentials and restricted all access to the affected portal.

Danbury Public Schools Superintendent Kara Casimiro confirmed the school system was also impacted by the data breach.

Casimiro notified district families and staff of the data breach in a letter Wednesday afternoon. Casimiro in that letter said the breached data included demographic data for students and families including school and state IDs, as well as contact information, address and date of birth. For educators and staff, the breached data included employment identification numbers, emails and phone numbers.

Casimiro said Social Security information is not stored in PowerSchool and was not breached.

She said the district is committed to transparency and is working with PowerSchool. She added PowerSchool recommends changing passwords as a precaution.

"We understand the concerns this incident may cause and deeply regret the situation," Casimiro said. "Our commitment to protecting the privacy and security of your information remains unwavering, and we will work closely with you to address any questions or issues."

In a statement, [Wallingford Public Schools](#) Superintendent Danielle Bellizzi said the information accessed includes data related to students, families and educators.

"PowerSchool and Wallingford Public Schools are committed to providing support and transparency throughout the process," Bellizzi said. "As information becomes available, Wallingford Public Schools will keep you informed."

Regional School District 16 stated that PowerSchool does not anticipate the data being shared or made public, and they believe that it has been deleted without any further replication or dissemination.

Louis Giancola, director of digital services at Milford Public Schools, said the district was also notified. He said the district's digital service team is working with PowerSchool to learn more about this cybersecurity incident.

"We are closely monitoring PowerSchool's response and holding them accountable to their commitments to transparency and security," he said.

East Hartford Public Schools are sending out communication to families, said Laura Roberts, the district's communications and marketing specialist.

South Windsor Superintendent Kate Carter said in a letter to parents, that while PowerSchool said the breach affected customers in the U.S. and Canada, its investigation shows South Windsor's data was not impacted. Carter said the district is doing its own investigation to ensure no data was compromised.

"We are actively assessing the situation and remain in close communication with PowerSchool to address any potential risks," she said. "As a precaution, we have implemented additional security measures to protect our data. Additionally, we have temporarily disabled external access to PowerSchool while we conduct our own investigation."

She said that access would affect users trying to access grades, attendance and other features outside of the district, but that the access would be restored Wednesday night.

Although it's unclear how many districts, both in Connecticut and across the country, were affected by the data breach, Susan Moore, Director of Technology for Meriden Public Schools, confirmed that their district was not impacted by the hack. She shared the statement that PowerSchool provided to the district.

“While this incident affected certain PowerSchool Student Information System customers, our thorough forensic investigation has confirmed that your organization’s data was not impacted,” PowerSchool said in a statement to Meriden.

In addition, PowerSchool said that the company is still analyzing their data and should they find changes, they will notify districts.

“Meriden Public Schools takes the safety and security of student and staff data very seriously and has procedures in place, including parental notification, should a breach occur,” Moore said. “In this case, the cybersecurity practices we have implemented prevented unauthorized access. Therefore, an official statement was not sent to parents.”

PowerSchool is expected to issue an official report on the incident to districts by Jan. 17.

Staff writer Michael Gagne contributed to this report.

Jan 8, 2025 | Updated Jan 8, 2025 5:35 p.m.



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Crystal Elescano covers education in the Meriden and Hartford areas. She graduated from the University of Connecticut with a journalism degree and has been covering communities throughout New Haven and Hartford counties since 2021.

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